

Idioms, Phrases, and Phrasal Verbs

1. Introduction

- In the **TNTET English Paper- I & II**, questions on **Idioms, Phrases**, and **Phrasal Verbs** often appear under **Vocabulary & Usage**.
- To score well, aspirants must know: The **meaning** (literal vs figurative), The **usage** (correct context), The **type** (phrase / idiom / phrasal verb)

2. Idioms and Idiomatic Expressions

An **idiom** is a phrase or expression whose **meaning is different from the literal meaning** of the individual words.

Idioms express **figurative meaning** and are **culturally specific**.

Standard VIII (Definition)

An expression, word, or phrase that has a **figurative meaning conventionally understood by native speakers**. This meaning is **different from the literal meaning** of the individual elements (i.e., they have a hidden meaning).

A. Food Idioms

Idiom	Figurative Meaning	Example
A bad egg	A dishonest person	He is a bad egg ; don't trust him.
A piece of cake	Very easy task	The exam was a piece of cake .
A couch potato	Lazy person	My brother is a couch potato on Sundays.
Bread and butter	Basic needs or livelihood	Teaching is his bread and butter .
Big cheese	Important person	The manager is the big cheese of this company.
Smart cookie	Clever person	She's a smart cookie , always solving problems quickly.

B. Sports Idioms

Idiom	Meaning	Example
The ball is in your court	It's your turn to act	I've done my part — the ball is in your court now.

Saved by the bell	Rescued at the last minute	I was saved by the bell when the teacher entered.
Strike out	Fail at something	He tried to start a business but struck out .
Jump for joy	Extremely happy	She jumped for joy on hearing the news.
On the ball	Alert and intelligent	You must stay on the ball in this job.
Front runner	Expected winner	India is the front runner in this competition.

C. Number Idioms

Idiom	Meaning	Example
On cloud nine	Very happy	She's on cloud nine after getting the job.
At sixes and sevens	Confused, disorganized	The house was at sixes and sevens after the party.
One-horse town	Small, dull place	He grew up in a one-horse town .
Take five	Take a short break	Let's take five before we continue.
Seventh heaven	Extreme happiness	He was in seventh heaven after his promotion.
Perfect ten	Completely perfect	Her performance was a perfect ten .

D. Colour Idioms

Idiom	Meaning	Example
Caught red-handed	Caught in the act	The thief was caught red-handed .
Black sheep	A disgrace to a group	He is the black sheep of the family.
Out of the blue	Suddenly	The news came out of the blue .

Once in a blue moon	Very rarely	We go to the beach once in a blue moon .
Gray area	Unclear situation	The rules are still a gray area .
A golden opportunity	Great chance	Don't miss this golden opportunity .

E. Animal Idioms

Idiom	Meaning	Example
At a snail's pace	Very slowly	The traffic moved at a snail's pace .
Let the cat out of the bag	Reveal a secret	She let the cat out of the bag about the surprise.
The lion's share	The largest part	The boss took the lion's share of the profit.
Watch like a hawk	Observe closely	The teacher watched the students like a hawk .
Fish out of water	Uncomfortable	I felt like a fish out of water at the party.
Mad as a hornet	Very angry	He was mad as a hornet after losing his phone.

3. Phrase

A **phrase** is a group of words that works together as a single unit in a sentence but does not express a complete idea.

A phrase **does not have both a subject and a finite verb**. Therefore, it cannot stand alone as a sentence.

Examples

- in the garden
- under the table
- a beautiful flower
- after the rain

Sentence Example:

The children are playing **in the garden**.

Here, **in the garden** is a phrase.

Types of Phrases

A. Noun Phrase

A **noun phrase** is a group of words that does the work of a noun.

Structure

Determiner + Adjective(s) + Noun

Examples

- a little boy
- the tall building
- those colourful flowers

In Sentences

1. **The little boy** won the race.
2. We visited **an ancient temple**.

Activity

Underline the noun phrase:

1. The old man crossed the road.
 2. A group of students visited the museum.
-

B. Verb Phrase

A **verb phrase** consists of a main verb and one or more helping verbs.

Examples

- is reading
- have finished
- will be playing

In Sentences

1. She **is singing** a song.
 2. They **have completed** the project.
-

C. Adjective Phrase

An **adjective phrase** describes a noun.

Examples

- full of joy
- rich in minerals
- eager to learn

In Sentences

1. The boy **eager to learn** asked many questions.
 2. The box **full of books** is heavy.
-

D. Adverb Phrase

An **adverb phrase** modifies a verb, an adjective, or another adverb.

It answers questions such as:

- How?
- When?
- Where?
- Why?

Examples

- with great care
- in the evening
- at school

In Sentences

1. The teacher explained the lesson **with great care**.
 2. We shall meet **in the evening**.
-

E. Prepositional Phrase

A **prepositional phrase** begins with a preposition and ends with a noun or pronoun.

Structure

Preposition + Noun/Pronoun

Examples

- under the tree
- in the classroom
- beside the river

In Sentences

1. The cat slept **under the tree**.
 2. The students sat **in the classroom**.
-

F. Infinitive Phrase

An **infinitive phrase** begins with **to + verb**.

Examples

- to win the match
- to help others
- to learn English

In Sentences

1. She wants **to become a doctor**.
 2. We came here **to study**.
-

G. Participial Phrase

A **participial phrase** begins with a participle (verb ending in *-ing* or *-ed*) and acts as an adjective.

Examples

- smiling brightly
- exhausted by work

In Sentences

1. **Smiling brightly**, the child greeted everyone.
 2. **Exhausted by work**, the farmer rested.
-

H. Gerund Phrase

A **gerund phrase** begins with a gerund (*verb + ing*) and acts as a noun.

Examples

- swimming in the river
- reading storybooks

In Sentences

1. **Reading storybooks** is my hobby.
 2. **Playing football** keeps us fit.
-

4. Phrasal Verbs

A **phrasal verb** is a **verb + preposition/adverb (or both)** that gives a **new meaning**, often **idiomatic**.

Standard VII (Definition in Idiomatic Phrase Context)

An **idiomatic phrase** consisting of a **verb and another element**, typically an **adverb or a preposition or both**, the **meaning** of which is **different from the meaning of its separate parts**.

Examples from Textbooks

Phrasal Verb	Meaning	Example
Set out	Begin a journey	We set out early in the morning.
Pick up	Collect or learn	She picked up her friend from school.
Get away	Escape or go on vacation	We'll get away for the weekend.
See off	Say goodbye	They went to the station to see off their uncle.
Get into	Enter (bus/train)	Please get into the car quickly.
Get off	Leave (bus/train)	We got off at the next stop.
Look into	Investigate	The police will look into the matter.
Put off	Postpone	The meeting was put off till Monday.
Give up	Stop trying	Don't give up on your dreams.
Get on	Have a good relationship	They get on well with each other.
Take over	Assume control	The new manager took over the company.
Look after	Take care of	She looks after her grandmother.
Kick off	Start	The event kicked off with a speech.
Call on	Visit	The doctor called on the patient.
Call back	Return a phone call	I'll call back in the evening.
Get rid of	Eliminate	We must get rid of old clothes.

Keep on	Continue	She kept on talking.
Shut down	Close permanently	The factory shut down last year.
Warm up	Prepare or heat	The athlete warmed up before the match.
Hang on	Wait or hold tightly	Hang on! I'll be there in a minute.

Types of Phrasal Verbs

A. Intransitive Phrasal Verbs

These do not need an object.

Examples

- wake up
- sit down
- get up

Examples in Sentences

- The baby **woke up**.
- Please **sit down**.

B. Transitive Phrasal Verbs

These need an object.

Examples

- turn off the light
- look after the child
- put on your shoes

Examples

- Turn off **the fan**.
- She looks after **her grandmother**.

C. Separable Phrasal Verbs

The object can come between the verb and the particle.

Examples

- turn on
- turn off
- put on

Examples

- Turn on the light.
- Turn the light on. Both are correct.

D. Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

The object cannot come between the verb and the particle.

Examples

- look after
- come across
- deal with

Examples

✓ She looks after her brother.

✗ She looks her brother after.

Difference between Phrase and Phrasal Verb

Phrase	Phrasal Verb
Group of words acting as one unit	Verb + particle forming a new meaning
May not contain a verb	Always contains a verb
Does not express complete meaning	Functions as a verb in a sentence
Example: in the garden	Example: look after

Examples

Phrase: The cat is sleeping **under the table**.

Phrasal Verb: The teacher **looked after** the students.

5. Idiomatic Phrases (Practice – Std IX & X)

Idiom/Phrase	Equivalent Meaning	Example
On the ball	Efficient, alert	You must stay on the ball to succeed.
Find one's voice	Gain confidence	She finally found her voice in class.
Over the moon	Extremely happy	They were over the moon after winning.
Sharp as a tack	Mentally quick	The new student is sharp as a tack .
Lend an ear	Listen carefully	Please lend an ear to my problem.
Go far	Succeed	With hard work, he'll go far in life.
Blow up	Explode	The balloon blew up suddenly.
Knuckle under	Submit	He finally knuckled under pressure .
Work out	Exercise / Solve	Let's work out at the gym. / We can work out the answer.
Bring it on	Accept a challenge	"You want to race? Bring it on! "

6. TNTET Examination Focus

Question Type	Common Pattern	Example
Meaning of an idiom	"Find the meaning of 'A piece of cake.'"	Easy task ✓
Phrasal verb usage	"Pick the correct meaning of 'Give up'."	Stop trying ✓
Word substitution	"Match idioms with single-word meanings."	Go far → Succeed ✓
Sentence-based test	"He was caught red-handed. What does it mean?"	Caught in the act ✓

Standard X

1. Defining Idioms, Phrases, and Phrasal Verbs (Review and Refinement)

Concept	Definition Emphasis
Idioms	Groups of words put together as a unit with a particular meaning that is not literal (figurative meaning). The meaning cannot be assumed based on the individual words.
Phrase	A small group of words put together as a conceptual unit . The meaning is literal , and it does not include the subject-verb pairing necessary for a clause.
Phrasal Verb	An idiomatic phrase consisting of a verb and another element (adverb or preposition or both), whose meaning is different from the meaning of its separate parts .

Key Points to Remember

- A **phrase** is a group of words without a complete thought.
- A **noun phrase** acts as a noun.
- A **verb phrase** acts as a verb.
- A **prepositional phrase** begins with a preposition.
- A **phrasal verb** is a verb combined with a preposition or adverb.
- The meaning of a phrasal verb is often different from the meaning of the individual words.

Example:

give = கொடு
trying)

up = மேலே

give up = கைவிடு (stop

This change in meaning makes phrasal verbs interesting and important in English.

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